GROW LOCAL CREATIVE • FOOTHILL ACTION GUIDE

5-Minute Google Maps Setup Checklist

How Cool, Auburn, Placerville & Divide businesses get found by local neighbors first.

Printable 1-Page Cheatsheet | No Tech Jargon | Updated for 2026

STEP 1 Fix the Rural Address Dilemma (P.O. Boxes vs. Home Offices)

- [ ] **Never list a P.O. Box:**Google algorithms suspend listings using P.O. Boxes or UPS Stores. Use your actual residence or shop.
- [ ] **Hide your home address:** If you serve customers at their homes/sites, check "I deliver goods and services" and toggle street address to ...
- [ ] **Designate specific Foothill service areas:** Add explicit cities: Cool (95614), Georgetown (95634), Auburn, Placerville, Greenwood, Pilot ...

STEP 2 Lock In High-Intent Primary & Secondary Categories

- [ ] **Primary Category is 60%+ of ranking weight:** Avoid generic tags like "Service" or "Contractor". Use specific terms like "Electrician", "Tre...
- [ ] **Add 3-5 precise secondary categories:** E.g., for BBQ: Primary "Barbecue restaurant", Secondary: "Caterer", "Takeout restaurant", "Fami...
- [ ] **Spy on the #1 competitor:** Search your trade in Auburn or Placerville on Google Maps. Notice the exact category badge under their name.

STEP 3 Upload Real Local Photos (Google Loves Local Proof)

- [ ] **Skip stock photography entirely:** Google detects stock images and demotes them. Real phone photos get 3x higher click-throughs.
- [ ] **The Essential 5 Photos:** 1) Your branded truck/trailer or shop sign on Hwy 49, 2) You/crew smiling, 3) 2-3 clean job-site or food results.
- [ ] **Natural GPS Geotagging:** Take photos with your phone camera location enabled. Google reads the Foothills metadata automatically.

STEP 4 Create Your Direct 1-Tap Google Review Shortlink

- [ ] **Eliminate friction:** Never tell clients "Find us on Google". Open your profile -> click "Ask for reviews" -> copy your shortlink (g.page/r/...).
- [ ] **The 30-Second Text Script:**"Hey [Name]! Thanks for having us out today. If you have 30 secs, a Google review means the world to our fa...
- [ ] **Keywords inside reviews count:** When happy locals mention "Cool", "Auburn", or "generator hookup", Google boosts your ranking for th...

STEP 5 The 60-Second Weekly "Google Post" Local Ranking Hack

- [ ] **Keep the listing active:** Profiles with updates in the last 14 days get prioritized over dead profiles. Spend 60 seconds every Friday.
- [ ] **The 2-Sentence Formula:** Upload 1 photo from this week + 2 sentences mentioning your town: "Wrapping up a custom metal roof out in ...
- [ ] **Zero ad spend needed:** Google feeds this fresh local activity directly into Google Maps search signals without paying for ads.

NEED A HAND GETTING MORE CUSTOMERS FROM THE LOCAL FOOTHILLS?

Grow Local Creative builds clean, lightning-fast websites and sets up local search profiles for trade contractors, specialty shops, and eateries in Cool, Auburn, Placerville, and the Georgetown Divide. No corporate fluff, just real local results.

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